

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: Identity, names and the source problem

CENTRAL QUESTION: what may be affirmed about a school whose own books are lost?

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NAMES OF ONE TRADITION (all three are used of the same materialist stream)

Cārvāka -> standard school label; etymologies from "to chew" / "pleasant speech"
are doxographers' explanations, NOT settled history

Lokāyata -> "the worldly / popular doctrine"; this-worldly, not world-renouncing

Bārhaspatya -> "of Bṛhaspati", the traditional founder; the attributed
Bṛhaspati-sūtra is LOST

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LOST PRIMARY CORPUS
no systematic
materialist treatise
survives

OPPONENT DOXOGRAPHY
Mādhava's Sarva-darśana-
saṃgraha; Śaṃkara; Jayanta
Bhaṭṭa; Śāntarakṣita;
Haribhadra; Kṛṣṇa Miśra's
Prabodhacandrodaya

QUOTED FRAGMENTS
about a dozen sūtras
and verses, preserved
only inside refutations

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ONE SURVIVING TEXT-WITNESS: Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa, Tattvopaplavaśiṃha
radical scepticism, not positive materialism -> LIMIT-CASE, not spokesman
school-affiliation contested ([CONTESTED]); never use him to state the defining thesis

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METHOD RULE -> state doctrine as "the standard doxographical reconstruction"
convergence across independent hostile witnesses fixes a recoverable core
hostile transmission exaggerates weak points and omits strong ones

TRAP -> "sources are hostile, so nothing can be said" is as wrong as
"the Bṛhaspati-sūtra proves it".

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: Classification, location and evidence grading

WHY IS CĀRVĀKA CALLED VEDA-REJECTING (nāstika)?

PRIMARY criterion -> rejects the authority of the Veda

SECONDARY sense -> denies existence after death

Cārvāka is nāstika in BOTH senses; Jaina and Bauddha schools are nāstika on the first criterion only, since they accept life after death

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ORTHODOX (āstika)	UNORTHODOX (nāstika)	COMMON ERROR
Nyāya, Vaiśeṣika, Sāṃkhya, Yoga, Mīmāṃsā, Vedānta	Cārvāka, Buddhism, Jainism	"nāstika = atheist" fails: Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā are non-theistic yet Veda-accepting

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HISTORICAL LOCATION ([CONTESTED] handle with care)

anti-ritual and naturalist currents are old: epic, Buddhist, Jaina and

Brahmanical reports precede later doxographical systematisation

Ajita Kesakambalī = important early materialist comparator, NOT proof that every early naturalist belonged to one organised Cārvāka school

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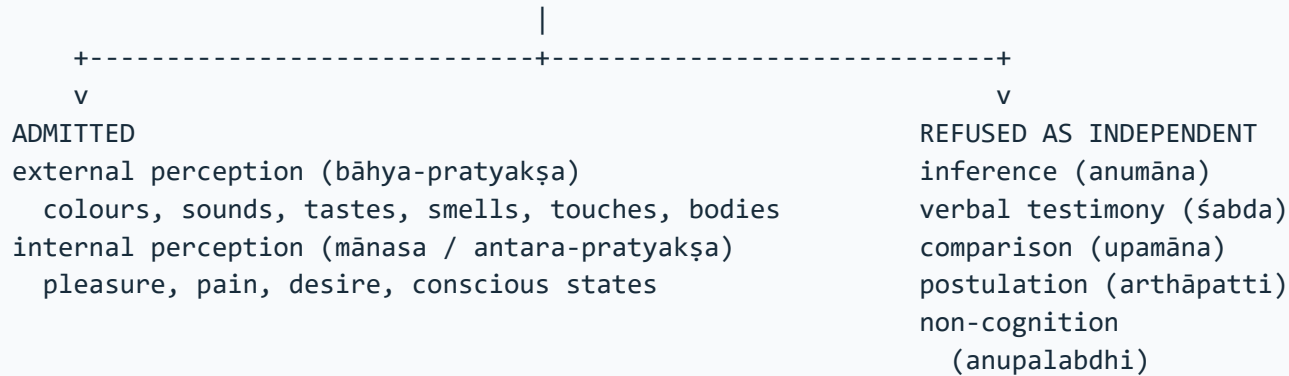
EVIDENCE GRADING USED THROUGHOUT THIS TOPIC

[ATTESTED] convergent doctrine [ANALYSIS] reconstruction [CONTESTED] disputed

ANSWER LINE -> "Cārvāka, also called Lokāyata or Bārhaspatya, is the Veda-rejecting materialist tradition; its positive system survives only through its critics."

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: The epistemic gate – perception alone

DEFINING THESIS: perception (pratyakṣa) is the ONLY independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa). Stronger than "perception is primary".



ARGUMENT IN FIVE STEPS

- 1 knowledge must be grounded in what is directly given
- 2 perception alone gives its object immediately
- 3 inference goes beyond the given, so it outruns certainty
- 4 testimony = trust in a speaker + an inference from words to facts
- 5 therefore perception alone is an independent means of valid knowledge

WHAT IS *NOT* DENIED

consciousness occurs and is internally perceived
what is refused is the further inference from awareness to an imperceptible bearer
TRAP -> "Cārvāka denies consciousness" is FALSE; it denies a transcendental self
PRESUPPOSITION [ANALYSIS] -> epistemic access fixes ontological commitment: admit into being only what can in principle be presented in perception.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: The attack on inference – three closed doors

EVERY INFERENCE NEEDS INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE (vyāpti): "wherever smoke, there fire"

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HOW COULD THAT UNRESTRICTED UNIVERSAL BE KNOWN?

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DOOR 1: PERCEPTION	DOOR 2: INFERENCE	DOOR 3: TESTIMONY	DOOR 4: (later lists)
finite survey only	needs a further	its own validity	comparison, postulation
past, future and	vyāpti -> circular	is unproved and	and non-cognition either
distant cases are	or infinite	itself inferred	add nothing new or
never observed	regress		borrow the same universal

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RESULT: vyāpti never rises above habit, expectation or probability
-> inference is not an independent means of valid knowledge

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SHARMA'S REDUCTIO ON TESTIMONY -> if testimony established vyāpti,
"none would be able to infer anything by himself"

ACCIDENTAL TRUTH -> some inferences are true, others fail; truth is a separable
accident of the practice, so predictive success proves nothing about status

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WHAT IS CONCEDED -> movement from sign to signified happens constantly
WHAT IS DENIED -> that such movement yields necessary, exceptionless knowledge
EXAM CONTROL -> state the doors as THREE. A vague "vyāpti cannot be proved"
throws away the marks that this argument is designed to carry.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Hidden limiting condition and self-refutation

HIDDEN LIMITING CONDITION (upādhi)

observed: smoke with fire, many times -> hasty universal: smoke proves fire
but what was constant may have been fire-PLUS-WET-FUEL, or combustion under an
unnoticed qualifier -> the supposed universal was too broad all along

STRUCTURAL, not quantitative: it survives however many cases are collected

TRAP -> upādhi is NOT the same as "too few instances observed"

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THE SOCRATES SYLLOGISM (2019, 15 marks) – where the objection lands

"All men are mortal / Socrates is a man / therefore Socrates is mortal"

FORM is conceded valid. The target is the MAJOR PREMISE, which is a vyāpti:

no one has perceived all men; relocating the relation to man-ness and mortality
does not help, because class-characters are not perceived either

VERDICT -> valid but epistemically empty: it transmits a certainty never acquired

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SELF-REFUTATION CHARGE (2019, 2025)

1 "no inference is a means of valid knowledge" quantifies over all inferences

2 no single perception delivers a universal

3 so the thesis is inferred (self-defeating) or undefended (unassertable)

4 Sharma presses further: thoughts and other minds are never perceived, so the
Cārvāka "can understand others only through inference"

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REPLY A: vitaṇḍā

assert nothing, only
destroy the opponent –
but four elements and a
body-self ARE asserted

REPLY B: softened thesis

deny apodictic certainty,
especially about the
transcendent – a weaker
but defensible doctrine

REPLY C: level-distinction

concede practical
validity, deny ultimate –
but that distinction is
"unknown to the Cārvāka"

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VERDICT [ANALYSIS] -> radical or consistent, but not both.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: The Nyāya defence and a balanced verdict

NYĀYA REBUILDS INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE WITHOUT OMNISCIENT SURVEY

agreement in presence (anvaya)	-> repeated positive co-observation
agreement in absence (vyatireka)	-> no counter-instance where the probandum is absent
elimination of suspected upādhis	-> known qualifiers identified and excluded
hypothetical reasoning (tarka)	-> denial of the relation makes experience incoherent; tarka removes doubt but is NOT itself a means of valid knowledge
perception of the universal	-> sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa in later Nyāya
the mark as qualified (parāmarśa)	-> no "leap" occurs; the sign is cognised together with the concomitance

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THE REAL LOCUS OF THE DISPUTE

BOTH sides agree finite observation cannot ENTAIL an unrestricted universal

Cārvāka: entailment fails -> no knowledge -> no means-of-valid-knowledge status

Nyāya : entailment fails -> warrant does not require entailment -> status stands

So the quarrel is about the CONCEPT OF KNOWLEDGE, not about the logic of induction

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WHY NYĀYA WINS AGAINST THE STRONG THESIS

universal denial is itself a universal;
other minds and ideas are never perceived;
the school still asserts elements and a self

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HONEST RESIDUE AGAINST NYĀYA [ANALYSIS]

tarka establishes nothing alone;
sāmānyalakṣaṇa works only inside
Nyāya realism about universals;
elimination removes only SUSPECTED
conditions, never proves that none
remains

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GRADED VERDICT -> justified against the strong thesis, but Nyāya answers by replacing omniscient certainty with disciplined, defeasible warrant – which concedes the Cārvāka's logical point while refusing his epistemological conclusion.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Testimony, the wider list, and the school ledger

WHY VERBAL TESTIMONY (śabda) IS REFUSED

- 1 testimony reports only that someone uttered something
- 2 the step from utterance to truth assumes competence and honesty
- 3 that assumption is not in the words; it is inferred
- 4 inference is already denied independent status -> testimony collapses
- 5 Vedic authorlessness and infallibility are not perceptually available

NOT DENIED -> ordinary communication; language may guide action until perception checks it. Usefulness is separated from means-of-valid-knowledge status.

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THE SAME CRITERION APPLIED TO THE LATER LIST [ANALYSIS] (systematic reconstruction)

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| comparison (upamāna) | -> resemblance is perceived; the stable word-kind relation needs generalisation |
| postulation (arthāpatti) | -> the postulated fact is unperceived and needs a universal rule excluding alternatives |
| non-cognition (anupalabdhi) | -> "if it existed here it would be perceived" is a universal conditional, not one perception |

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LEDGER OF ADMITTED MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE – CĀRVĀKA FIXES THE LOWER BOUND

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| 1 Cārvāka | perception |
| 2 Vaiśeṣika, Buddhism | + inference |
| 3 Sāṃkhya-Yoga | + testimony |
| 4 Nyāya | + comparison |
| 5 Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā | + postulation |
| 6 Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā, Advaita | + non-apprehension |

STRUCTURAL POINT -> every richer epistemology must justify its additions against Cārvāka; that is why he is the standing pūrvapakṣa of Indian philosophy.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Material ontology – four elements and own-nature

ONTOLOGICAL MINIMALISM: admit only what perception can present

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FOUR ELEMENTS (bhūtas): EARTH + WATER + FIRE + AIR

eternal material bases; their combination and dissolution produce bodies,
sense organs, objects and living organisms

ĀKĀŚA IS REJECTED -> it is not perceived; the Nyāya inference from sound to an
imperceptible substratum inherits the disputed vyāpti problem

TRAP -> writing "five elements" is the single most punished factual slip here

PYQ ANCHOR -> 2020 Q6(b), 15 marks: rejection of ākāśa + criticism of transmigration

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OWN NATURE (svabhāva) [ATTESTED]

fire burns, water flows down, thorns are sharp,
the peacock is variegated, stone is hard

REGULARITY IS REAL; only TRANSCENDENT causation
is denied – no karma, no adṛṣṭa, no divine will
explanation stops at an OBSERVABLE nature

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ACCIDENTALISM (yadṛcchāvāda) [CONTESTED]

events occur by chance, with
no determining cause at all

DETERMINATE CAUSATION IS
DENIED; listed by doxographers
among ahetuvāda positions and
attacked by Buddhists, Jainas
and Naiyāyikas alike;
the Cārvāka link is CONTESTED

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OBJECTION -> "burns by its own nature" is a refusal to explain, not an explanation

REPLY [ANALYSIS] -> every explanatory chain terminates somewhere; "God willed it" is also
terminal and far less observable. RESIDUAL FORCE [ANALYSIS] -> the school still gives no
account of WHY natures stay stable, which is precisely what vyāpti-theory supplies.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Self, body and emergent consciousness

THE LIVING BODY IS THE SELF (dehātmavāda)

- 1 conscious life is only ever met with as embodied
- 2 no self is perceived apart from bodily states
- 3 so an extra substance called ātman is an unwarranted addition
- 4 explain awareness instead as a property of the bodily complex

IDENTITY-LANGUAGE ARGUMENT -> "I am stout", "I am thin" predicate bodily properties directly of the person. Opponent: "my body" separates possessor from possessed.

Reply: possessive grammar alone does not prove a separable substance.

EVIDENCE -> injury, intoxication, age, sleep and disease visibly alter awareness

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CONSCIOUSNESS FROM THE ELEMENTS (bhūta-caitanya)

- betel analogy -> leaf + lime + areca nut give a RED not present in any part
fermentation -> kiṇvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam: intoxicating power
arises from fermenting agents that lack it separately

CLAIM -> an organised whole can display a NOVEL property absent from ingredients

NOT the claim that consciousness is identical with any one element

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FOUR MATERIALIST SELF-MODELS [CONTESTED] (Sadānanda, Vedāntasāra) OBJECTIONS AND REPLIES

gross body (sthūla-śarīra) / senses (indriya) /
vital processes (prāṇa) / mental organ (manas)

SHARED CORE -> none survives bodily dissolution

BOUNDARY -> this is NOT the crude/refined contrast

Jaina: an emergent
property needs a bearer
Advaita: consciousness is
self-luminous; the body
is known BY it
Reply [ANALYSIS] -> positing an
immaterial soul renames
rather than explains

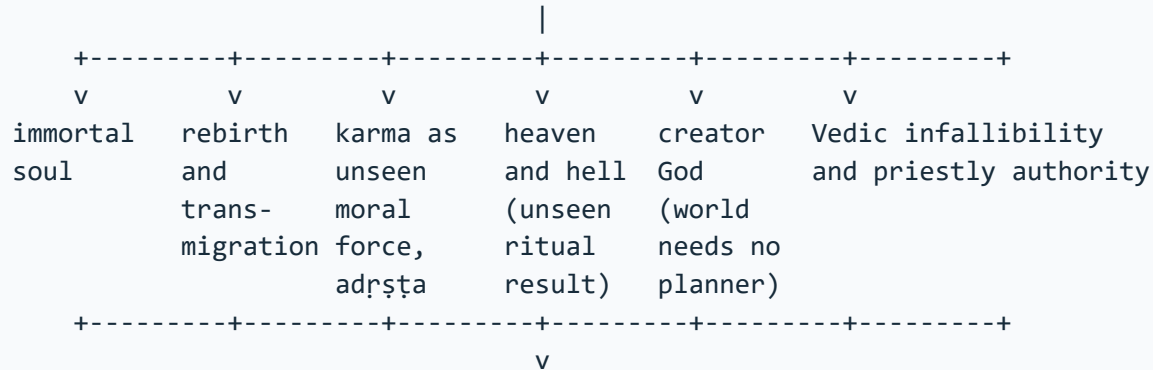
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HONEST LIMIT [ANALYSIS] -> emergence is asserted, not explained: redness and intoxicating
power are third-personal, whereas awareness is first-personal.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: The rejection of transcendent entities

ONE TEMPLATE, APPLIED REPEATEDLY

X is imperceptible -> only inference or testimony could reach X -> neither is an independent means of valid knowledge -> X is not admitted



LIBERATION (mokṣa) IS CANCELLED, NOT REDESCRIBED

opponent-preserved formula [CONTESTED] "death itself is liberation"
(maraṇam eva apavargaḥ) -> dissolution ends the person and so ends suffering;
it describes no positive post-mortem state

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RITUAL CRITIQUE -> sacrifice and ancestral offerings promise unseen results that cannot be verified; the satire that ritual sustains priestly livelihood is SUPPLEMENTARY to the epistemological argument, never a substitute for it
e.g. the mocking challenge that if the sacrificial victim goes to heaven, the sacrificer should offer his own father – a polemical fragment, not a treatise

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OBJECTION -> without karma and rebirth the moral order collapses
REPLY [ANALYSIS] -> morality need not be underwritten by cosmic bookkeeping; pleasure, pain, prudence and social consequence are enough for conduct
STRUCTURAL VERDICT -> Cārvāka is the only Indian school whose atheism follows from its EPISTEMOLOGY rather than from cosmology or soteriology; non-theism is common in India, but this-worldliness is Cārvāka's alone. PYQ ANCHOR -> 2021 Q5(e).

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Ethics, society and anti-caricature control

THE FOUR HUMAN ENDS, FILTERED

dharmā -> rejected where it rests on scriptural command or unseen reward
mokṣa -> rejected: it presupposes a separable self and a post-mortem destiny
artha -> ADMITTED as the INSTRUMENT
kāma -> ADMITTED as the END

HIERARCHY MATTERS -> pleasure is the end, wealth its means; they are not co-equal

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PRUDENTIAL STRUCTURE, NOT RECKLESS APPETITE

husk-and-grain image -> do not discard grain because it carries a husk;
secure pleasure while limiting foreseeable pain
traditional verse [ANALYSIS] "as long as one lives, let one live happily"
(yāvat jīvet sukhaṃ jīvet) -> cite as a DOXOGRAPHICAL verse associated with the
school's image, never as a line from an extant primary text

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SOCIAL AND POLITICAL SIDE [CONTESTED] (thin evidence)

statecraft (daṇḍanīti) and livelihood (vārttā)
reported inside the Lokāyata curriculum;
some Cārvākas "regard the king as God"

READING [ANALYSIS] -> a secular theory of authority:
order comes from the sovereign, not from cosmic
dharma; prosperity from the productive arts

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CRUDE vs REFINED [CONTESTED]

dhūrta -> the caricatured,
everything-is-body version
suśikṣita -> allows practical
inference (lokaśiddha), and is
the strongest reply to the
self-refutation charge
BOUNDARY -> doxographical and
indirect; NOT two documented
schools with surviving texts

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EVALUATION [ANALYSIS] -> two things the rivals supply are missing: a QUALITATIVE ranking of
pleasures and an account of OTHER-REGARDING obligation. Honest verdict: a coherent
theory of PRUDENCE and an incomplete theory of MORALITY.

CONTROL -> call it naturalistic hedonism or this-worldliness; do not reduce a
serious epistemological school to a slogan about eating and drinking.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Comparative map, PYQ rail and answer spine

COMPARATIVE AXES – USE THESE FIVE, NEVER A VAGUE "MATTER vs SPIRIT"

AXIS	CĀRVĀKA	NYĀYA	BUDDHISM	JAINISM
knowledge	perception only	four means	perception + inference	many means + standpoints
self	living body	enduring ātman	no substantial	plural jīvas
causation	observed nature	real relation	dependent orig.	persisting
transcendent	all denied	God, soul, karma	karma, no creator	karma as matter
liberation	death ends person	apavarga	nirvāṇa	mokṣa of jīva

KEY DISTINCTIONS -> Cārvāka denies TRANSCENDENCE but keeps a MATERIAL BEARER;
Buddhism denies SUBSTANTIALITY but keeps MORAL CONTINUITY, and rules out the body-self by name, since material form is itself an aggregate declared not-self.

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DIRECTLY OWNED PYQ RAIL (Paper I, Section B)

- 2018 Q8(b) 15 cross-school acceptability of the rejection of inference
- 2019 Q5(c) 10 consistency of the rejection of inference
- 2019 Q6(c) 15 what is wrong with the Socrates syllogism
- 2020 Q6(b) 15 rejection of ākāśa + criticism of transmigration
- 2020 Q7(c) 15 Cārvāka and Jaina conceptions of reality
- 2021 Q5(e) 10 bearing of epistemology on the rejection of transcendent entities
- 2024 Q5(a) 10 is the philosophy positivistic?
- 2024 Q6(a) 20 Cārvāka refutation of self vs Buddhist rejection of ātman
- 2025 Q5(a) 10 grounds for rejecting inference
- SUPPORTING 2022 Q7(c) 15 (Nyāya-owned): the Naiyāyika reply to these objections

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ANSWER SPINE -> define + flag reconstruction -> perception-only thesis ->
three doors + upādhi -> Nyāya reply -> derive ontology (four elements, body-self,
emergent awareness) -> transcendent denials -> ethics -> ONE comparison ->
QUALIFIED VERDICT: a rigorous empiricist protest and a decisive standing
pūrvapakṣa, but not a complete theory of knowledge, since the exclusive perceptual
criterion is narrower than the reasoning needed to defend it.